NUTRITION

Reading food labels for heart health

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

What should you check first?

Food labels can help you compare products, but start with the serving size. The nutrition panel usually describes one stated serving, not the whole package. Check how much you expect to eat. Label formats vary, and the listed serving is not a recommendation for your personal portion size. [1,2,4]

Compare like with like

Two products may use different serving sizes. One could show nutrients per portion while another uses a fixed weight. Comparing the printed numbers without noticing that difference can be misleading. Ask your nutrition counselor to demonstrate using foods you buy often. A fair comparison considers the same amount of food, as well as how much you realistically eat. Keep a calculator handy if it helps.

Find the nutrients that matter

For heart-healthy choices, sodium, saturated fat, and added sugars are useful parts of the label to discuss. Fiber can also be relevant. Do not judge a product only by its calorie figure or one bold claim on the front. Your medical needs may require attention to other nutrients. Ask which values matter most for your own eating plan and how to use them together. [1,3,5]

Know the limits of daily values

Some labels show a percentage of a daily reference value. This can help compare products, but it is not a personal prescription. The reference may use a general diet that differs from your needs. If you have a sodium, fluid, potassium, or other restriction, follow the instructions from your doctor. Ask how those instructions relate to the information on products available locally. [1,2]

Read the ingredient list too

The ingredient list provides information beyond the nutrition panel. It may help you understand what is in a product and whether it contains an ingredient you need to avoid. If you have an allergy, follow your allergy care plan and ask when wording is unclear. Do not assume that a product labeled natural, light, or healthy is automatically suitable for your treatment needs.

Practice with a regular purchase

Choose two versions of a food you buy often. Check serving size, relevant nutrients, ingredients, cost, and how the food fits your meals. You might decide that a small preparation change is more practical than buying a new product. Bring any uncertainty to your nutrition visit. The purpose of label reading is to support a useful decision, not to make every shopping trip feel like an examination.

Use labels within the whole meal

Consider the whole meal, including portions, sauces, and snacks. A lower-sodium product is only one part of the choice. Bring a label you find confusing to your next nutrition visit and ask for an example.

References

1. U.S. Food and Drug Administration. (n.d.). What's on the nutrition facts label. https://www.fda.gov/food/nutrition-facts-label/whats-nutrition-facts-label

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3. American Heart Association. (2026, March 31). Diet and lifestyle recommendations. https://www.heart.org/en/healthy-living/healthy-eating/eat-smart/nutrition-basics/aha-diet-and-lifestyle-recommendations

4. U.S. Food and Drug Administration. (n.d.). Serving size on the nutrition facts label. https://www.fda.gov/food/nutrition-facts-label/serving-size-nutrition-facts-label

5. National Health Service. (n.d.). Food labels. https://www.nhs.uk/live-well/eat-well/food-guidelines-and-food-labels/how-to-read-food-labels/

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